

Beats are not always quarter notes

The most common time signature is 4/4, followed by 3/4 and 2/4, but the beat does not always have to be a quarter note. It could be a half note (in which case the bottom number would be 2), a eighth note (the bottom number is 8), or an sixteenth note (the bottom number is 16).



△ 2/2 time signature

Each measure has two beats, and the beats are half notes.



△ 3/2 time signature

Each measure has three beats, and the beats are half notes.



△ 3/8 time signature

Each measure has three beats, and the beats are eighth notes.



△ 3/16 time signature

Each measure has three beats, and the beats are sixteenth notes.

Common and cut time

The C time signature symbol, often called "common time," is exactly the same as 4/4. Another symbol you might see is the C symbol with a line through it. This is the same as 2/2 and is often called "cut time."



◁ Common time, or 4/4

The C is just another way of writing 4/4. There are four quarter notes in each measure.



◁ Cut time, or 2/2

This is another way of writing 2/2. There are two half notes in each measure.

LOOKING CLOSER

Unusual time signatures

A versatile time signature, 4/4 is very common in pop music. But there is no rule against having an unusual top number, and a composer may choose this if he wants a different rhythmic feel. "Mars" from *The Planets* by Gustav Holst is a famous example of a piece in 5/4.



◁ 5/4 time signature

There are five beats in each measure, and the beats are quarter notes.



◁ 7/8 time signature

There are seven beats in each measure, and the beats are eighth notes.

REAL WORLD

Waltz

Musicians are not the only people who need to know about meter and time signatures. Dancers also count beats and measures. Different types of dance are distinguished by their meter, and by their typical rhythms. Waltzes are in 3/4 or 3/8, tangos in 2/4, and both use characteristic rhythmic patterns.

